5.2 Writing executable scenarios

Scenarios written in this format will make up the core of your executable specifications. But to make them truly executable, you need to integrate them into your projects.

In this section, you'll see how to do this in both JBehave and Gherkin. Gherkin is the language used by Cucumber and the vast majority of Cucumber-based BDD tools, including SpecFlow (for .NET), Behave (for Python), and many others. JBehave uses a very similar format: there are slight variations between the tools, but I'll point them out along the way.

Scenarios are stored in simple text files and grouped by feature. These files are called, logically enough, *feature files*.

5.2.1 A feature file has a title and a description

At the top of a feature file is a section where you can include the description of the corresponding feature. For example, in JBehave, you could write something like this:

```
Earning Frequent Flyer points from flights

Narrative:
In order to encourage travellers to book with Flying High Airlines
more frequently
As the Flying High sales manager
I want travellers to earn Frequent Flyer points when they fly with us

Scenario: Earning standard points from an Economy flight
Given the flying distance between Sydney and Melbourne is 878 km
And I am a standard Frequent Flyer member
When I fly from Sydney to Melbourne
Then I should earn 439 points
```

1 The feature title.

Narrative keyword introduces an optional description. **2**

3 A short description of the feature.

One or more scenarios follow.

The first line **1** is used as a title for the feature. Dan North suggests that the title should describe an activity that a user or stakeholder would like to perform.[2] This makes the work easier to contain and the scope easier to nail down. For example, "Earning Frequent Flyer points from flights" is a relatively well-defined user activity: when it's implemented, Frequent Flyer members will be able to earn points when they fly. On the other hand, "Frequent Flyer Point Management" might also include rewarding Frequent Flyer members points when they make purchases with partner companies, letting members view their current point status, and so forth.

In addition to the title, it's a good idea to include a short description of your feature so that readers can understand the underlying business objectives and background behind the scenarios that the file contains.

In JBehave, the `Narrative` keyword **2** is used to mark the start of an optional, free-form description **3**. As illustrated here, it's common to use the Feature Injection format you saw in chapters 3 and 4 ("In order to ... As a ... I want") to describe a feature.

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[2] See Dan North's article, "What's in a story," for some interesting tips on writing well-pitched stories and scenarios: http://dannorth.net/whats-in-a-story/.